Sharma was baffled by this question. 'You want to sack that bastard,' he said. 'You also want to torture the traitor. That is the easiest thing to do. But what do you do thereafter? If you want to nail a traitor, you need to have solid evidence of betrayal. You need to have the details of his handlers so that the leaking line can be plugged for the future. When Rabinder was put under surveillance, there were reports that he was regularly having lunch meetings with an intelligence officer handling Pakistan operations and a desk officer handling some African countries. It could be assumed that they might have innocently given the traitor certain pieces of intelligence that he could sell for dollars. How one sanitises such activities was the biggest challenge.'

Sharma also revealed that many spies involved in the surveillance on Rabinder Singh were often agitated whenever he copied classified intelligence reports procured from colleagues, charming them with praise and treating them to meals at expensive restaurants.

'Since his room was bugged, they could hear every discussion he had with the officers manning different desks. These officers never suspected that while he shared a cup of coffee with them, he was stabbing them in the back. Welcome to the treacherous terrain of espionage. You never know who is spying against whom, which officer has been compromised and being run as a double agent by the foreign intelligence outfits. You feel as though you're living in a black hole. For me, it was like seeing an Aldrich Ames behind his innocent face,' said Sharma.

Aldrich Ames worked at the CIA from 1962 and got his first overseas assignment in Turkey in 1969. In 1985, while working in the CIA's Soviet division, he switched sides and walked into